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Spinal Cord Stimulation for Chronic Pain Management: Patient Information Leaflet

This leaflet provides essential information about Spinal Cord Stimulation, which is a very advanced modality to manage pain in patients unresponsive to many other interventions for pain management.

What is a Spinal Cord Stimulator (SCS)?

A Spinal Cord Stimulator (SCS) is an implantable medical device designed to manage chronic pain when other treatments (e.g., medications, physical therapy) have not worked. It consists of:

1. Leads (thin wires): Placed near your spinal cord.
2. Generator (battery): Implanted under the skin (usually in the buttock or abdomen).
3. Handheld programmer: Lets you adjust settings.

The SCS delivers mild electrical pulses to your spinal cord, interrupting pain signals before they reach your brain.

How does SCS Work?

The SCS works by:

1. Masking pain signals with gentle electrical pulses, creating a tingling sensation ("paresthesia").
2. A new setting allows SCS to work without tingling sensations as well.
3. Disrupting pain pathways to reduce pain intensity.
4. Reducing reliance on pain medications for many patients.

Note: Patients choose the setting which works best for them. SCS does not cure the underlying cause of pain but helps manage feeling of pain.

Who Might Benefit?

An SCS may be considered if you have:

1. Chronic pain lasting >6 months (e.g., failed back surgery syndrome, nerve damage, complex regional pain syndrome).
2. Pain is not controlled by medications, injections, or surgery.
3. A successful trial period (see below).

You will NOT be a candidate if:

- You have untreated depression/addiction, uncontrolled bleeding disorders, or infections.

The Two-Step Process

1. Trial Stimulation (Test Run)

What happens?

1. Procedure is performed under local anesthesia and sedation.
2. Leads are temporarily placed near your spine (via a needle) and tunneled under your skin.
3. Wires connect to an external battery worn on a belt.
4. Duration: 5–10 days.
5. Goal: Test if pain reduces by $\geq 50\%$.
6. Success – you proceed to permanent implant.
7. No improvement – leads are removed.

2. Permanent Implant Surgery

1. Done under local anesthesia and sedation.
2. Leads are secured near the spine; the generator is placed under the skin.
3. Avoid bending/lifting for 4–6 weeks.
4. Stitches removed in 7–14 days.

Risks and Complications

SCS is generally safe, but risks include:

Common (temporary)

Swelling, bruising, or discomfort at the implant site.

Rare (<5%)

1. Infection (may require device removal).
2. Lead movement or breakage.
3. Nerve damage, bleeding, or spinal fluid leaks needing further procedures or surgery to treat
4. Device malfunction (e.g., battery failure).

Stimulation issues:

Tingling may feel too strong/weak (adjustable via programming with your handheld device).

Contact your doctor immediately if you experience:

Fever, severe pain, redness/drainage at the incision site, or sudden loss of pain relief.

Living with Your SCS

Battery Life

- Rechargeable: Lasts 8–10 years.
- Non-rechargeable: Replaced every 2–5 years (minor surgery).

Daily Use

- Use the programmer to turn the SCS on/off or adjust intensity.
- Most activities (e.g., walking, light exercise) are encouraged.
- Avoid: Contact sports, heavy lifting, or twisting.

Special Precautions

MRI scans: Many modern SCS devices are MRI-compatible ‘only under specific conditions’ – always inform your radiologist.

1. Security systems: May trigger alarms (show your SCS ID card).
2. Electromagnetic sources: Avoid welding, power transformers, or lying directly on wireless chargers.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q: Will the SCS eliminate all my pain?

A: Most patients report 50–70% pain reduction and improved function, but results vary.

Q: Can I shower with the SCS?

A: Yes, after incisions heal (typically 2–4 weeks post-surgery).

Q: What if the stimulation feels uncomfortable?

A: Your clinician can reprogram the device remotely or in-person.

Q: How soon will I feel pain relief?

A: During the trial, relief is immediate for many. After permanent implant, allow 4–6 weeks for full recovery.

Q: Can I travel?

A: Yes! Inform airport security—your SCS card exempts you from body scanners.

Key Contacts

For emergencies (e.g., signs of infection, severe pain):

Present to your local emergency department and inform them about the procedure you had.

Questions? Contact Your Care Team

Before/after procedure:

 782-377-7813

 Info@redsandspm.com

In an emergency

→ Call 911, or visit your local emergency department

